with Russia, Sinkiang and Tibet. He hobnobbed with the Russians, much to the chagrin of the British, who were always wary of Russian Czar Alexander II's designs on India. This was the era when the long-drawn game of imperial domination in Central Asia played out between Britain and Russia.[14]

In 1846, Maharaja Gulab Singh inherited the tenuous hold of the Sikh Empire on Gilgit. However, in 1852, a tribal rebellion forced his forces to retreat to Bunji on the east bank of the Indus. Ranbir Singh finally recaptured Gilgit in 1860.

In 1861, to the north of Gilgit, in China-controlled Sinkiang, the writ of the Chinese Manchu Emperor Xian Feng collapsed when Sinkiang's Muslims rebelled and severed the only line of communication between this area and metropolitan China. Taking advantage of this situation, Maharaja Ranbir Singh despatched a small force in 1864 across the Karakoram Pass to Shahidullah (Xaidulla) located between Leh and Kashgar. He also established a military post there and informed the neighbouring warlords about it.

Since 1855, during the rule of Maharaja Gulab Singh, the British had been carrying out the Great Trigonometrical Survey of India, thereby surveying every part of the state. Ten years later, the only part that was left to be surveyed was the north-east corner of Ladakh, including the route from Leh to the Karakoram Pass. This job was entrusted to an Anglo-Indian survey official named W. H. Johnson. Johnson held a grudge against the British for their racist attitude towards his Anglo-Indian ancestry. The Maharaja exploited this and offered him post-survey employment if he agreed to carry out some survey to aid the state's diplomatic ambitions.

In 1865, Johnson crossed over to Khotan in Sinkiang from Leh. On his return, he told the Maharaja that the north-eastern border of the state was, in fact, some 100 miles north of the Karakoram Pass. It extended into what, in the absence of field data, was believed to be Chinese territory. The state's border lay within 50 miles of Khotan.

The British were not amused when they figured out that the Maharaja was devising his own militaristic foreign policy. Helpless, they decided to